Site and Context

Schöneberg around Kärntener Straße

HISTORY

In the late 19th century, Schöneberg grew rapidly from a village into a dense city district. Within a few decades the open land around the site was built up into a continuous grid of Gründerzeit blocks. Kärntener Straße 26, built in 1899, belongs to this period of rapid urban growth.



1879



1901

HISTORICAL MAPS Schöneberg in 1879 and 1901; the project site is marked in yellow



1901



Today

FIGURE-GROUND · 1901 AND TODAY Built mass in black, open space in white; the project site in red

Neighbourhood

Landmarks around the site

Today the site lies in a well-connected and lively part of Schöneberg. Within walking distance are parks, transport hubs, sports grounds and places of historic significance, giving the rebuilt corner a strong setting for both housing and a public ground floor.



LANDMARKS Places around the project site, numbered as in the text

1 Rudolph-Wilde-Park

An urban oasis laid out between 1906 and 1914 around the U-Bahn station Rathaus Schöneberg, a peaceful green ribbon loved by locals for walking, reading and playing boules.

2 Rathaus Schöneberg

Seat of West Berlin's government from 1949 to 1990 and a global symbol of the divided city's desire for freedom.

• Project site

Kärtnener Straße 26

3 Innsbrucker Platz

A key transport hub with U-Bahn and S-Bahn stations, linking central Berlin with the southern districts.

4 Dominicus-Sportplatz

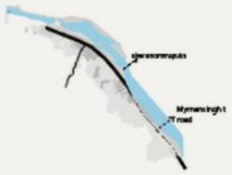
A sports ground with seating for around 4,500 spectators, established in 1920 and modernised in 2019/2020.

5 Natur-Park Schöneberger Südgelände

A former railway yard turned nature reserve and art park, with tracks, a steam locomotive and a water tower.

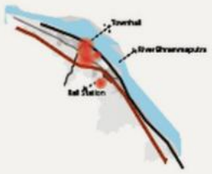
Chronological Diffusion

How the city grew away from its heritage and its river



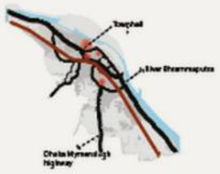
1750–1800

Nasirabad becomes a district in 1787, along the river.



1800–1900

The railway arrives; the Old Town Hall opens in 1878.



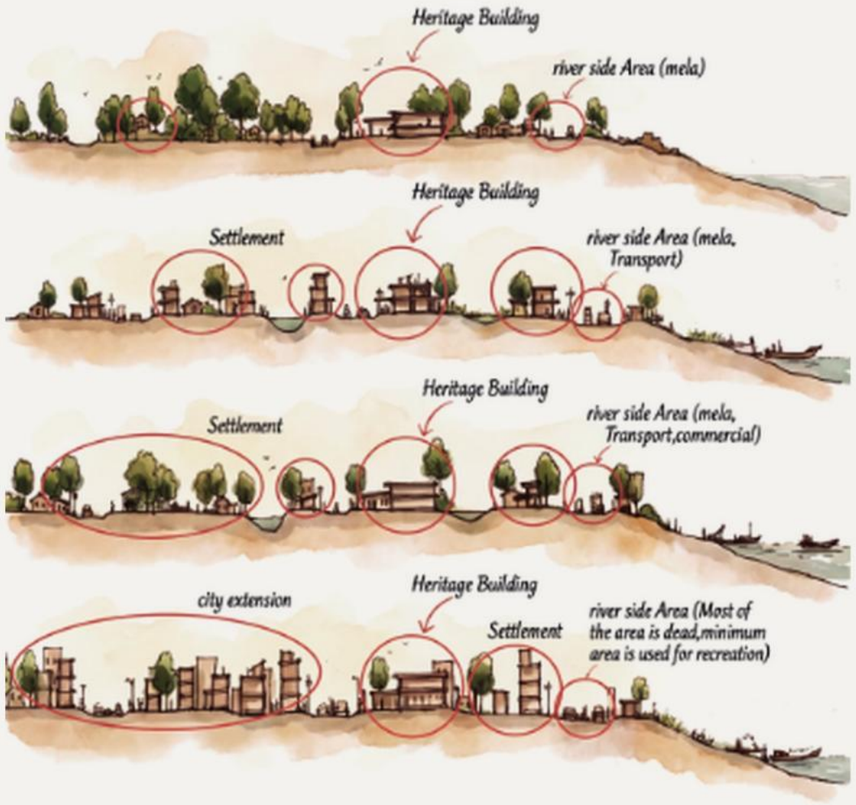
1901–2000

Growth along the railway and the Dhaka–Mymensingh highway.



Today

The historic core and the riverside fall to the margins.



SECTIONS THROUGH TIME Heritage buildings and the riverside, once places of fairs, transport and trade, are increasingly hemmed in by settlement and city extension. Today most of the riverside lies unused.

A Network Left Behind

Heritage between the river and the railway

Mymensingh began as a small settlement on the banks of the Brahmaputra. The river was its lifeline: it carried goods and people, and its banks were the place for fairs (*mela*), trade and gathering. As the town expanded, first around the Town Hall and the railway, and later along the Dhaka–Mymensingh highway, its centre of gravity moved steadily away from the water.

The heritage buildings that once stood at the heart of daily life were gradually surrounded by new development. Many of them, such as Shashi Lodge, Alexander Castle and Gauripur Lodge, are now closed to the public, used for unrelated purposes or in poor condition. The lively riverside lost its role as well: today most of the riverfront is inactive, and only a small part is used for recreation.

The heritage map shows how these historic buildings are scattered between the river and the railway. Together they still form a rich network, but one that is no longer connected to the everyday life of the city.



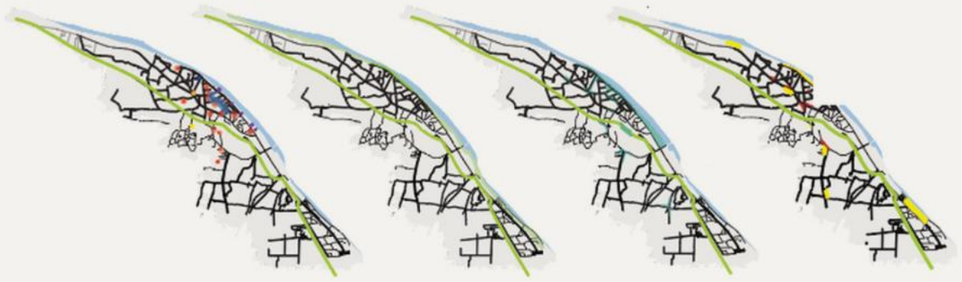
HERITAGE MAP Historic buildings across the city, between the river and the railway (green line)

From Issues to Design

Planning at three scales

Each issue was translated into steps of a design process, and then into design considerations at three scales: the township, the study area and the single heritage site.

ISSUES	DESIGN PROCESS	DESIGN CONSIDERATIONS
Broad issue Heritage is disconnected from its urban fabric	→ – Heritage-centred area – Road network	→ **Township level** 1. A heritage-centred area defined from the city's historic core 2. The Brahmaputra riverfront reconnected to the city as a continuous public park
Specific issues 1. No common platform for exploring heritage 2. The city is cut off from the river 3. Scarce open space in the city core	→ – River connected with the city – A clear hierarchy of open spaces	→ **Study area level** 3. A network of open spaces, linked by walkable streets with active building fronts 4. Through traffic kept out, with clear entry points into the area 5. Mixed uses that bring different income and social groups together
	→ – Heritage buildings linked by a trail – Supporting facilities: shared, commercial and cultural	→ **Heritage site level** 6. A heritage trail linking Shashi Lodge, Alexander Castle, Gauripur Lodge, Hasan Manzil and other historic buildings 7. Historic buildings given new public uses, with new buildings around them respecting their character



1 Heritage-centred area 2 Riverside 3 Places of daily use 4 Overlap: the study area

OVERLAY Three layers are combined to find where heritage, river and daily life meet

Selecting the Study Area

Where heritage, river and daily life overlap

The study area was selected by overlaying three layers: the heritage-centred area, the riverside, and the places of daily use, such as recreation, shopping, administration and walking. Where all three meet, a heritage trail can connect historic buildings, the river and everyday life.



Heritage-centred area Riverside Daily uses Heritage trail

HERITAGE BUILDING	BUILT	PRESENT CONDITION
Alexander Castle	1879	Library of a teachers' training institute, surrounded by educational institutions; condition at risk
Mymensingh Judge Court	[ ]	Government building in public use, surrounded by temporary shops
Shashi Lodge	1897	Preserved by the government; walled compound with no visual connection from outside
Mymensingh Museum (Bagan Bari)	1900	Museum since 1969, with too little space; poor condition
Gauripur Lodge	[ ]	Closed to the public, used by Sonali Bank
Hasan Manzil	1910	First Muslim historical landmark of the city, used as a health complex; poor condition

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ISSUES	DESIGN PROCESS	DESIGN CONSIDERATIONS
Broad issue Heritage is disconnected from its urban fabric	→ – Heritage-centred area – Road network	→ **Township level** 1. A heritage-centred area based on the city's history 2. Existing central amenities and social activities kept 3. The river connected to the city through recreation
Specific issues 1. No common platform for exploring heritage 2. The city is cut off from the river 3. Scarce open space in the city core	→ – River connected with the city – A clear hierarchy of open spaces	→ **Study area level** 1. Open spaces distributed across the area 2. Defined entry points; through traffic discouraged 3. Mixed and overlapping land uses 4. Local and historical character in new buildings 5. Integration of different income and social groups 6. A walkable environment with active building fronts
	→ – Heritage buildings linked by a trail – Supporting facilities: shared, commercial and cultural	→ **Heritage site level** 1. Heritage buildings identified 2. Historic character respected in surrounding buildings 3. Heritage buildings reused



RIVERSIDE The reconnected riverfront, with a new bridge and terraced edge along the Brahmaputra

A Theatre in the Round

Performance at the heart of the building

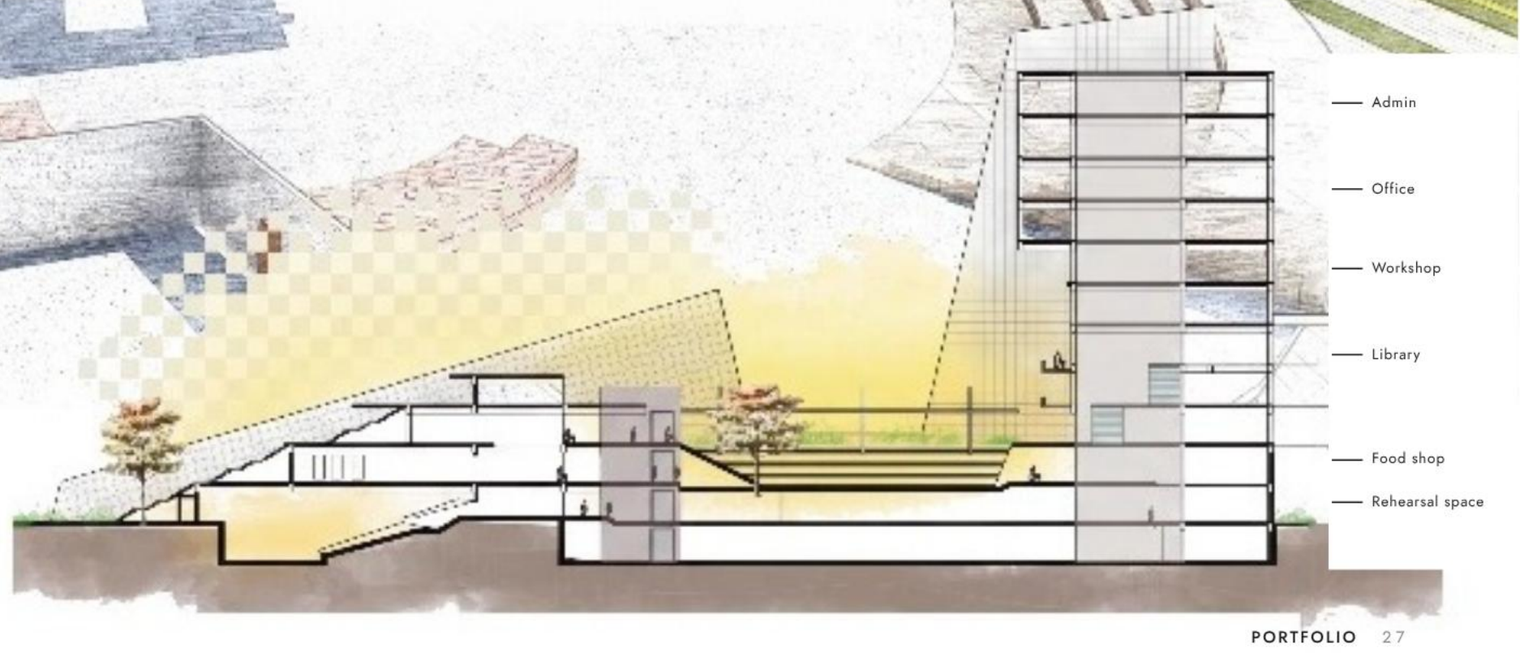
THE TOWER

The tower holds the working side of the centre: administration, offices and workshop above, with the library, food shop and rehearsal space below. Its glass façade, screened by slender vertical fins, keeps it light and open, and marks the centre from the Hatirjheel link road.

DESIGN

Jatra is traditionally performed in the round: an open arena with the audience gathered on all sides of the stage. The design deliberately builds on this tradition. A circular open-air amphitheatre forms the heart of the building, its stepped seating sloping down towards a round stage. The curved wings wrap around this space, so rehearsal rooms, the library and workshops all look onto the performance below. A long bridge links the two wings across the courtyard.





PERSPECTIVE The open-air amphitheatre, with stepped seating around a round stage and the tower behind

SECTION (right) From the sunken amphitheatre to the tower with workshop, offices and administration